
Methods: Microscopy

Microscopy is a powerful and relatively simple tool available to archaeologists to identify microscopic traces of food remains. While microscopy is used in zooarchaeology, ceramic studies, and other methods of analysis, its primary use in the archaeology of foodways is in identifying microscopic plant remains, mainly starch granules and phytoliths. Here, we review the basics of light microscopy and electron microscopy, followed by an extended cases study that illustrates how microscopy can result in new discoveries in paleoethnobotany. This research was conducted by a BU undergraduate as her senior honors thesis and is published in the *Journal of Archaeological Science*; you are assigned the article (Johnson and Marston 2020) as a supplementary reading for this module.